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Nonprofit at center of rift in City Hall

Amid audit, top aide intervened on behalf of antiviolence group

By Alice Yin
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Mayor Brandon Johnson's top aide intervened in a heated dispute this year between Johnson's health commissioner and a politically connected antiviolence group that receives millions in public money despite concerns over how the nonprofit tracks its workers.

The clash unfolded after the Chicago Department of Public Health's 2025 review into the recipients of its community violence interruption grants found issues with collecting data from Acclivus Inc. It followed health Commissioner Dr. Olusimbo Ige's complaints that the organization sought to circumvent the city's required contracting and payment protocols before she was pushed out of the administration.

Acclivus executives spent months staunchly protesting the audit's findings with officials at the health department, which manages the city's antiviolence grants. The conflict played out under the watchful eye of Johnson's senior adviser, Jason Lee — an unusual involvement for a high-ranking mayoral staffer, given that the \$8 million grant is administered by a separate department.

Johnson's ties to Acclivus include a donation his campaign made to the nonprofit, which also employs a well-known South Side activist whose consulting business has done political work for him as well as Ald. Pat Dowell, the mayor's handpicked Finance Committee chair and ally until last year.

During a back-and-forth with Ige's team this March over how much the city was paying the organization, Acclivus Chief Operating Officer Sheila Regan went over the health commissioner's head and appealed to Lee by cc'ing him on an email the Tribune received via a public records request.

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'Unimaginable'

Agonized families await answers after remains recovered from funeral home on South Side

By Gregory Royal Pratt, Tess Kenny and Olivia Olander
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The Young family hired South Chicago Chapel to prepare Keith, one of seven siblings, father of three and garage door installer, for his visitation. They gathered at a Baptist church on the West Side Thursday and waited to receive his body.

As the hours ticked by, the family grew anguished. They called the funeral home director, Johanna Morgan, who told them there was police activity in the neighborhood blocking the way but promised to deliver Keith for visitation.

He never made it.

Deja Young, left, hugs Corrine Young as they wait for news on their deceased relative, Keith Young, at the Cook County medical examiner's office on Friday. Keith's visitation had been planned for Thursday, but his body never showed up to the church. **ARTHUR MAIORELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

"They had us under the impression that there was some kind of investigation going on outside the funeral home which hindered them from being able to move around," recalled Leetonie Young, Keith's older brother. "We were under the impression the police would finally let them do what they were supposed to be doing, not knowing the police presence was about them."

The family's experience came after authorities recovered 56 bodies from South Chicago Chapel, removing them slowly throughout the night and into the morning and driving them to the morgue for the painful process of reuniting them with their families.

Records obtained by the Tribune reveal a harrowing scene at the funeral home and a history of problems at a previous crematorium run by its owners. Nearly five dozen decomposing bodies were discovered during a walkthrough of the business at 2939 E. 95th St. after a complaint was filed reporting that remains were not being properly stored at or below 40 degrees Fahrenheit, in accordance with state regulations, according to a police incident report.

Inside the funeral home, sources told the Tribune, authorities encountered bodies on gurneys but also on shelves alongside equipment. Some of the bodies were not bagged, and some appeared to have severed limbs.

Late Friday, a police spokesman said Calumet Area (Area 5) detectives are conducting a criminal investigation.

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Experimental pancreatic cancer drug may be 'game changer'



Rachelle Gardner and her fiancé, Tom Perlongo, smile as they walk out of an exam room at City of Hope Cancer Center Chicago in Zion on July 30. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

New treatment won't cure deadly disease, but it could extend patients' lives by many months

By Lisa Schencker
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

When she heard about a new, experimental drug to treat pancreatic cancer, Rachelle Gardner tried not to get her hopes up.

She wondered: Would she be eligible for the medication? Would her hospital be allowed to give it to her? Would she live long enough to get it?

In late July, her questions were answered. In an exam room at City

of Hope Cancer Center Chicago, Gardner shook three light blue pills out of a bottle and, sipping water, swallowed them one at a time.

"To good health and getting rid of that cancer bug!" Gardner exclaimed cheerfully after downing the last pill.

Gardner, a 59-year-old Milwaukee teacher for students who are visually impaired, said the medication has given her "a new sense of hope."

Gardner is one of dozens of

patients in Illinois and across the country who in recent weeks have started receiving the experimental medication, which has been heralded as a breakthrough. The drug, called daraxonrasib, does not cure pancreatic cancer, which is one of the deadliest and most difficult-to-treat cancers, but it gives many patients the next best thing: more time.

Typically, once pancreatic cancer spreads in the body beyond the pancreas, patients may only have months to live. But in a recent clinical trial, the drug was given

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"This is the thing that changes what we can offer patients. It's the first targeted therapy we're able to offer them, the first thing other than just giving chemotherapy."

DR. EVAN PISICK, a medical oncologist at City of Hope Cancer Center Chicago

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